

08 — Tricky Questions, Salary, Notice Period and Closing

Tricky questions test **honesty and calmness**. The rule: tell the truth briefly, stay positive, and end with what you learned or what you're doing now.

A. Job changes and experience

1. You changed 4 companies in under 4 years. Why?

"Each move had a clear reason and gave me more responsibility. Shaligram was my first job, and the role was changing to non-development work. At MSAI, the main project was handed over to the client and the team was released. At Morpheme I learned AWS and DevOps but worked on short client projects, and I wanted full ownership of a product, which I got at Atiya. Now I'm looking for a long-term role where I can grow in one place."

2. Why only about one year at each company? Will you leave us too?

"My early moves were about finding the right growth path, and some were outside my control, like the project handover at MSAI. Now I'm clear that I want to be a backend engineer in a strong product team, and this role fits that. I'm looking to stay long term and grow into a senior role here."

3. You joined Atiya in August 2025. Why are you leaving so soon?

"At Atiya I got full ownership and built 8 applications, which taught me a lot. But I'm mostly working alone on these codebases. I want a bigger engineering team with code reviews, system design discussions and products at larger scale. I'm not running away from anything — I'm looking for the next step in growth."

4. Your resume says 4 years. Isn't it about 3 years 8 months?

"Yes, exactly — I started in February 2023, so it's about 3 years and 8 months. I round it to almost 4 years." *(Always be exact if asked. Never argue.)*

5. Your title is MERN Stack Developer. Why apply for backend?

"My work has always been mostly backend — APIs, databases, queues, caching and deployment. I can build React screens, but the backend is where I add the most value, so I want to focus there."

6. Why didn't you get promoted?

"I moved for better responsibility instead of waiting for a title. In practice, I've done senior-level work — I led TorahAnytime with code reviews and production deployment, and at Atiya I own complete systems."

B. Questions that check if your resume is real

7. "Explain this resume line in detail." (any line) Be ready to explain every line with the 5-step formula from file 04. If one line is hard to explain, simplify it on the resume before applying.

8. "Did you really build all of this alone?"

"At Atiya, yes — the design, code and deployment are mine. I worked with business users for requirements and the IT team for server and database access. Most apps share the same layered template, and I used code generation for the 463 models, which made it faster. I can walk through any part."

9. "How did you measure 30% / 40% / 20% improvement?" - 30% API response time → "Measured average response time in logs and Postman before and after optimisation." - 40% deployment efficiency → "Manual deployment time and failure rate before vs after CI/CD." - 20% engagement → "Analytics numbers shared by the client after the redesign." *If you are not sure of a number, say "around" and explain how it was observed.*

10. "You wrote Kubernetes / Nest.js / Microservices. Have you used them in production?" Be honest about the level:

"Kubernetes — I used it on TorahAnytime for deployments, mainly working with existing configs, not designing the cluster. Nest.js — I know the structure (modules, controllers, providers, guards) and have built with it, but most of my production work is in Express." *(Adjust to the truth.)*

11. "Why isn't there a GitHub repo for these projects?"

"These are company and client projects, so the code is private. I can explain the architecture and code in detail, and I have personal projects on GitHub."

12. "Your GitHub commits show a different name/account." (if relevant)

"Those repositories are under the company's GitHub account. My commit identity there is the company-configured one."

C. Weakness and failure traps

13. "What is a skill you are weak at?"

"Large-scale distributed systems design — like Kafka at very high scale or designing multi-region systems. I understand the concepts and I'm practising system design, but I haven't designed one at that scale in production yet."

14. "What is something you'd do differently in your projects?"

"Start with TypeScript, write unit tests from day one, keep secrets out of the repo from the beginning, and set up CI/CD even for internal apps."

15. "Why is there no test coverage in your apps?"

"As a single developer under delivery pressure, I focused on validation, health checks, Postman collections and testing with real users. The CRM has Jest + Supertest. In a team I'd add service-level unit tests and contract tests."

16. "Why IIS and not Docker/cloud at Atiya?"

"It's the company's infrastructure standard — Windows Servers managed by IT with on-premise databases. I learned iisnode deeply. For the public WhatsApp app I used Cloudways with PM2. I've used Docker and AWS at Morpheme and I'm comfortable with them."

D. Salary and notice period

Before the interview, fill this:

Item	Your answer
Current CTC (fixed + variable)	_____ LPA
Expected CTC	_____ LPA (research Glassdoor / AmbitionBox / Naukri for "Node.js developer, 3–5 yrs, your city")
Minimum you will accept	_____ LPA (keep this private)
Notice period	_____ days (buyout possible? yes / no)
Earliest joining date	_____

"What is your current CTC?"

"My current CTC is [X] LPA." — Be honest. It's checked with payslips.

"What is your expected CTC?"

"Based on my experience in Node.js backend, the responsibility I've handled, and market range for this role, I'm expecting around [Y] LPA. I'm flexible depending on the overall package and growth opportunities."

"That's too high. Can you come down?"

"I understand. I'm more interested in the role and growth. Could you share the budget for this role? If the overall package and the growth path are good, I'm open to discussing."

"Why such a high hike?"

"My responsibilities have grown a lot — I own complete backend systems in production. The expected amount is in line with the market for this skill set and experience."

"What is your notice period? Can you join early?"

"My notice period is [N] days. I'll speak to my manager about an early release and can try to join sooner if needed."

E. Questions YOU should ask at the end (always ask 2–3)

Pick the ones that fit the round.

To the technical interviewer 1. "What does the backend architecture look like — monolith or microservices?" 2. "What does the deployment pipeline look like, and how often do you release?" 3. "How are code reviews done in the team?" 4. "What's the biggest technical challenge the team is working on right now?"

To the manager 5. "What would success look like for this role in the first 90 days?" 6. "How big is the team, and who would I work with most closely?" 7. "How do you support developers to grow into senior roles?"

To HR 8. "What are the next steps in the process?" 9. "What is the team culture like — remote, hybrid or office?"

Never ask in the first round: leave, salary hike cycle, "what does your company do?"

F. Closing the interview

Last line (say it with a smile):

"Thank you for your time. I really enjoyed this discussion, especially about [something they said]. I'm very interested in this role and I'm confident I can contribute to your backend team. I look forward to hearing from you."

After the interview: Send a short thank-you email or LinkedIn message within 24 hours.

Subject: Thank you — Node.js Backend Developer interview

Hi [Name], thank you for the interview today. I enjoyed learning about [team/product]. I'm excited about the opportunity to contribute to your backend team with my experience in Node.js, databases and production systems. Looking forward to the next steps. Regards, Sandeep Lodhi | +91 6266921342